

ESSENTIAL SCALES

HANDBOOK



FOR METAL GUITARISTS

by Bradley Hall

INTRO

A scale is "any consecutive series of notes that form a progression between one note and its octave, typically by order of pitch".

I'm sure most of you (hopefully) already know that much. But the world of scales is seemingly **infinite, complicated** and, let's face it, kinda **dull**!

Some incredibly common questions I get asked by students are...

"Which scales should I learn?"

"What are the best scales for soloing?"

"How do I use X scale?"

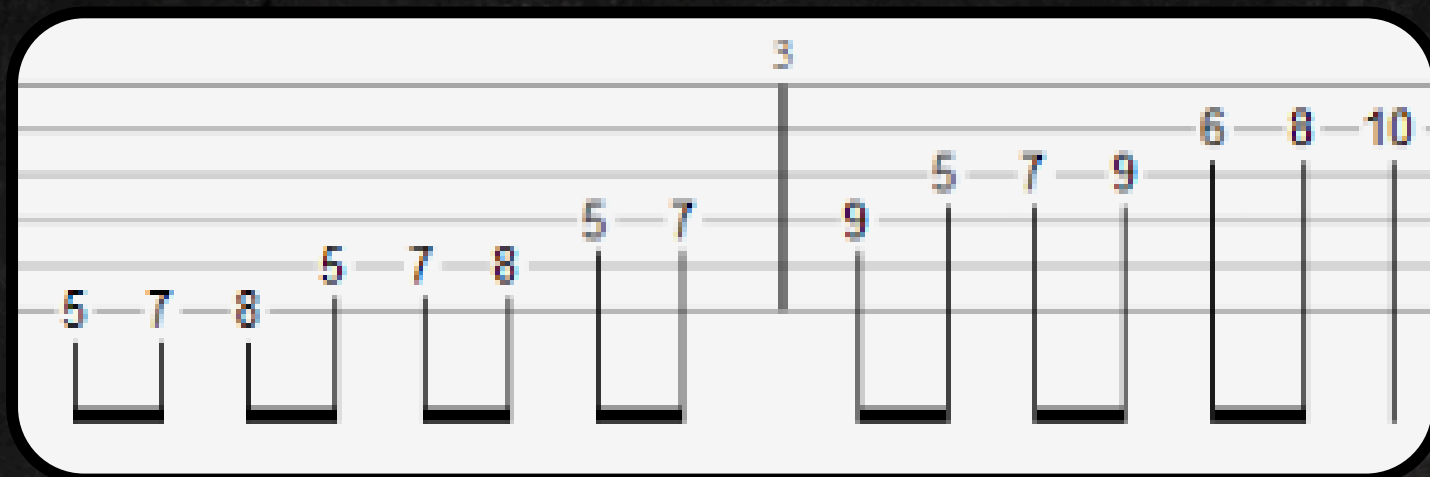
So I thought it was about time I took the liberty of creating a handy, light weight resource you guys can use to answer these questions and save you a bunch of time!

In this book you'll find a list of **by far** the most useful and commonly-found scales in the Rock/Metal world and some quick tips on how best to apply them.

Please keep in mind this book is meant as a **reference guide** and assumes some basic theory knowledge. More in-depth material can be found at Bradley Hall's Guitar School!

MINOR (AEOLIAN)

Intervals: root, 2nd, min 3rd, 4th, 5th, min 6th, min 7th



The A minor scale (2 octaves)

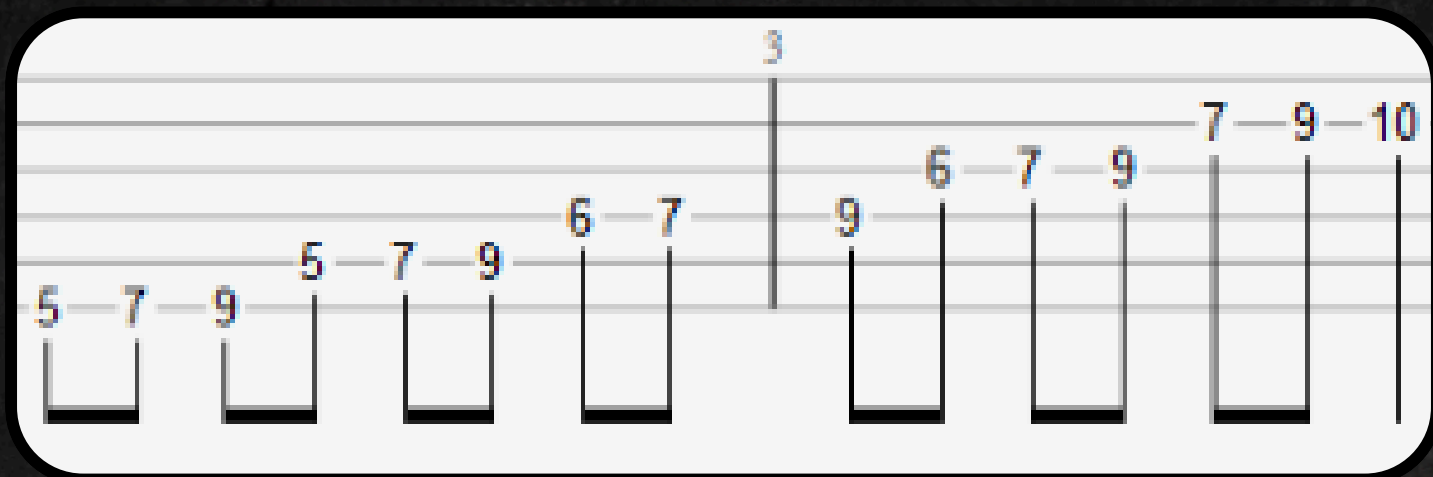
When to use: the minor scale is the default scale to use when you're playing diatonically in a minor key.

Tip: if you really want to get the most out of the minor scale you need to lean into its more colorful intervals. The root, 4th and 5th are very safe intervals, whereas the 3rd and 6th intervals have a lot more flavor, and the 2nd and 7th have even more flavor. Train your ears to understand how each interval sounds!

Example chord progression: Am | F | G

MAJOR (IONIAN)

Intervals: root, 2nd, maj 3rd, 4th, 5th, maj 6th, maj 7th



The A major scale (2 octaves)

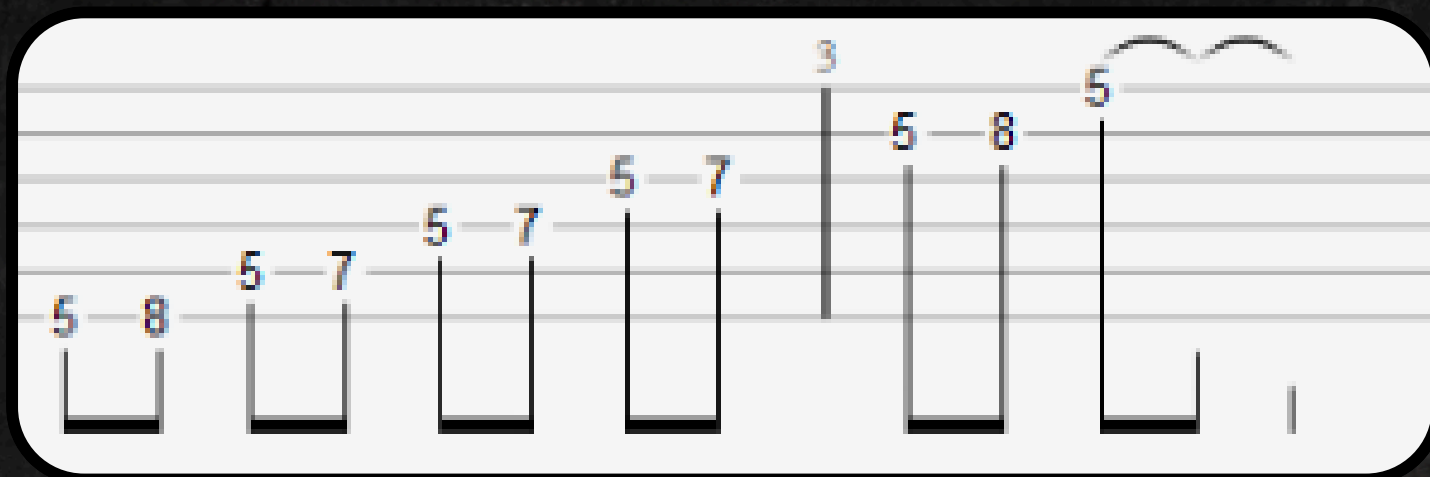
When to use: the major scale is the default scale to use when you're playing diatonically in a major key.

Tip: if you really want to get the most out of the major scale you need to lean into its more colorful intervals. The root, 4th and 5th are very safe intervals, whereas the 3rd and 6th intervals have a lot more flavor, and the 2nd and 7th have even more flavor. Train your ears to understand how each interval sounds!

Example chord progression: A | D | E

MINOR PENTATONIC

Intervals: root, min 3rd, 4th, 5th, min 7th



The A minor pentatonic scale (2 octaves)

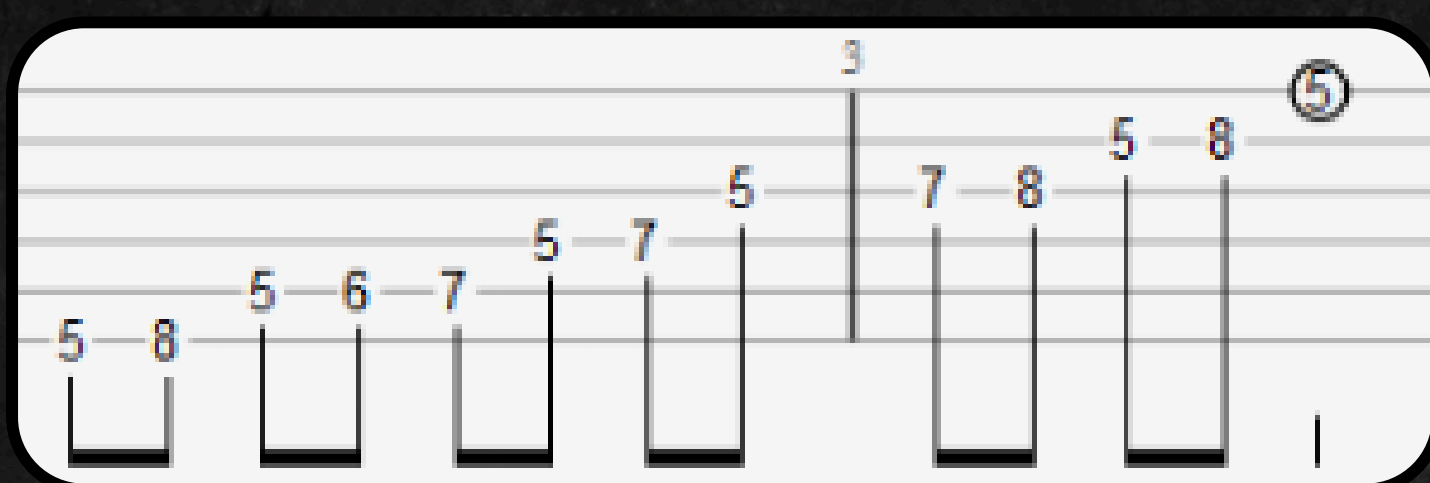
When to use: the minor pentatonic scale is mostly used as a substitute for the regular minor scale and can be used interchangeably. It's usually most effective when you want to achieve a more Blues-y sound.

Tip: you can make the minor pentatonic sound a lot more exciting if you play its intervals in different orders, instead of consecutively. For example, instead of playing root, 3rd, 4th, 5th; try root, 3rd, 5th, 7th.

Example chord progression: Am | F | G

MINOR BLUES

Intervals: root, min 3rd, 4th, flat 5th, 5th, min 7th



The A minor Blues scale (2 octaves)

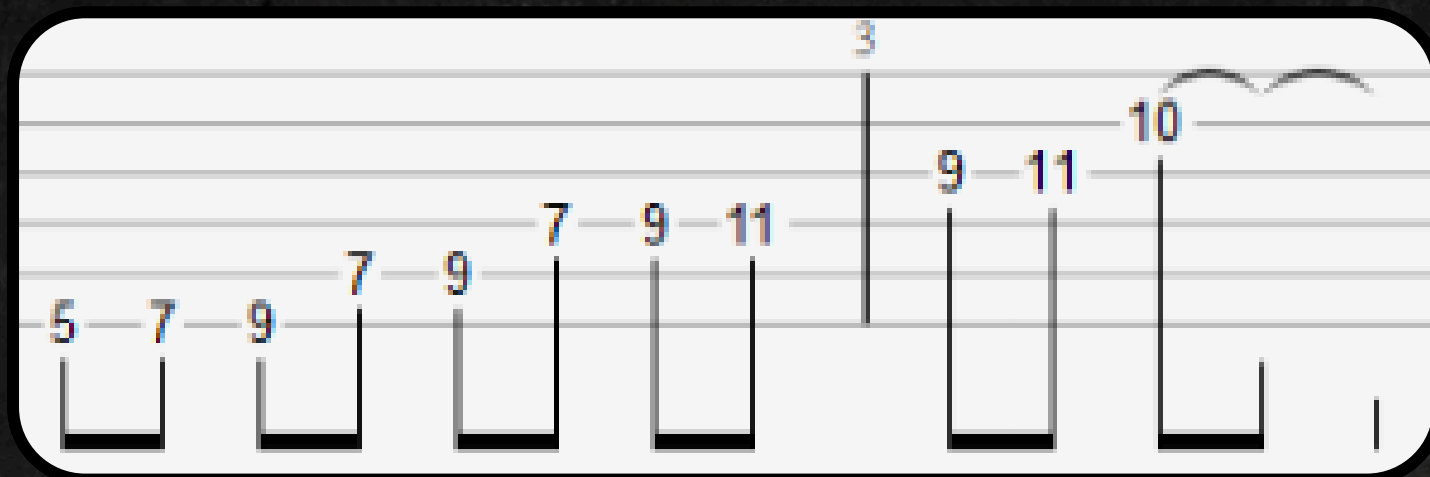
When to use: the minor Blues scale is simply just a minor pentatonic scale with an extra note added. It has exactly the same applications as the minor pentatonic but allows you to lean harder into that special Blues flavor.

Tip: in most cases the added flat 5 note should only be used as a passing tone and not lingered on.

Example chord progression: Am | F | G

MAJOR PENTATONIC

Intervals: root, 2nd, maj 3rd, 5th, maj 6th



The A major pentatonic scale (2 octaves)

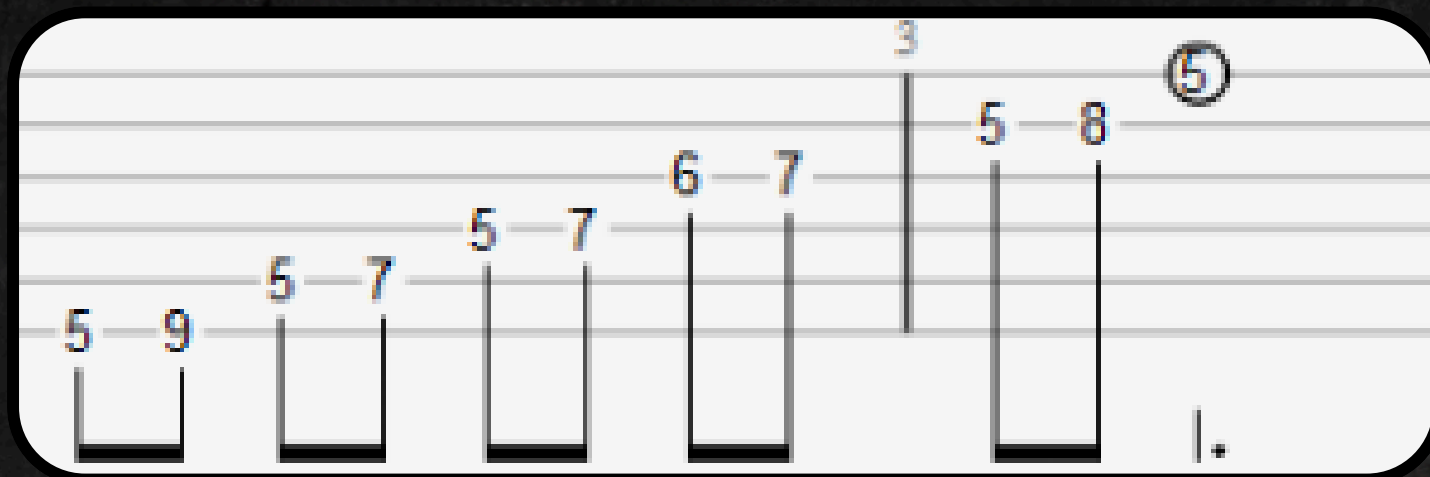
When to use: the major pentatonic scale is mostly used as a substitute for the regular major scale and can be used interchangeably. It's most commonly implemented over major Blues progressions.

Tip: you can easily find the major pentatonic box in a given key by taking the regular minor pentatonic box shape and simply moving it down 3 frets!

Example chord progression: A | D | E

MIXOLYDIAN PENTATONIC

Intervals: root, maj 3rd, 4th 5th, min 7th



The A mixolydian pentatonic scale (2 octaves)

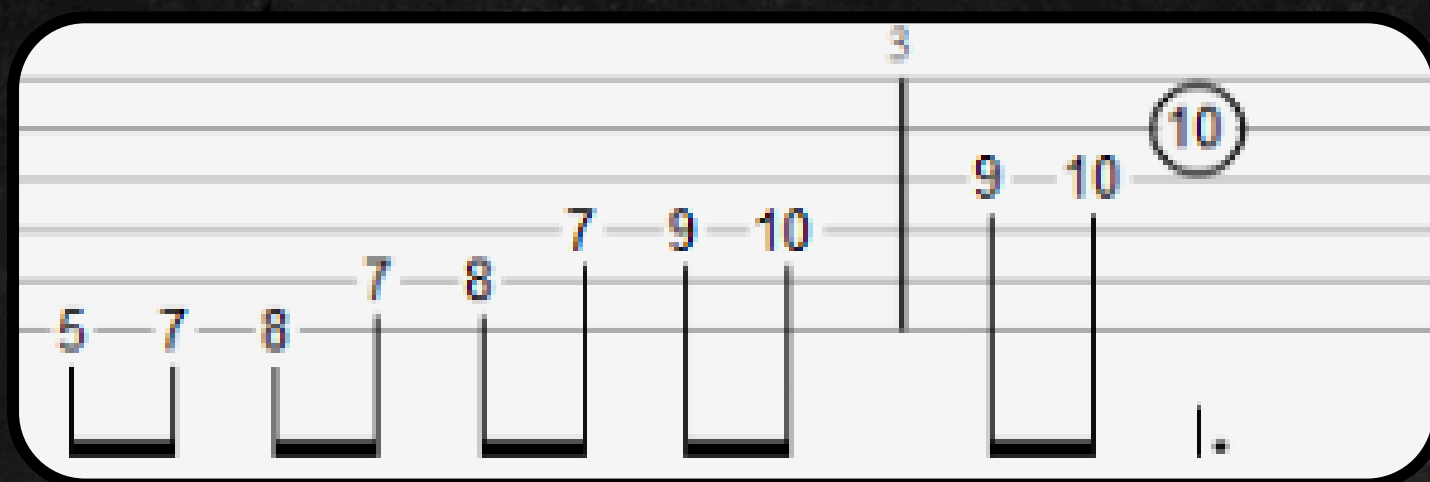
When to use: the mixolydian pentatonic scale is a cut-down version of the mixolydian mode and can therefore be used interchangeably with it. However, in many cases, it can also just be used as a substitute for the major/major pentatonic scale.

Tip: because of its min 7th interval, this scale is at its most effective when the underlying harmony consists of dominant 7th chords (i.e. A7).

Example chord progression: A7 | D7 | E7

HIRAJOSHI

Intervals: root, 2nd, min 3rd, 5th, min 6th



The A hirajoshi scale (2 octaves)

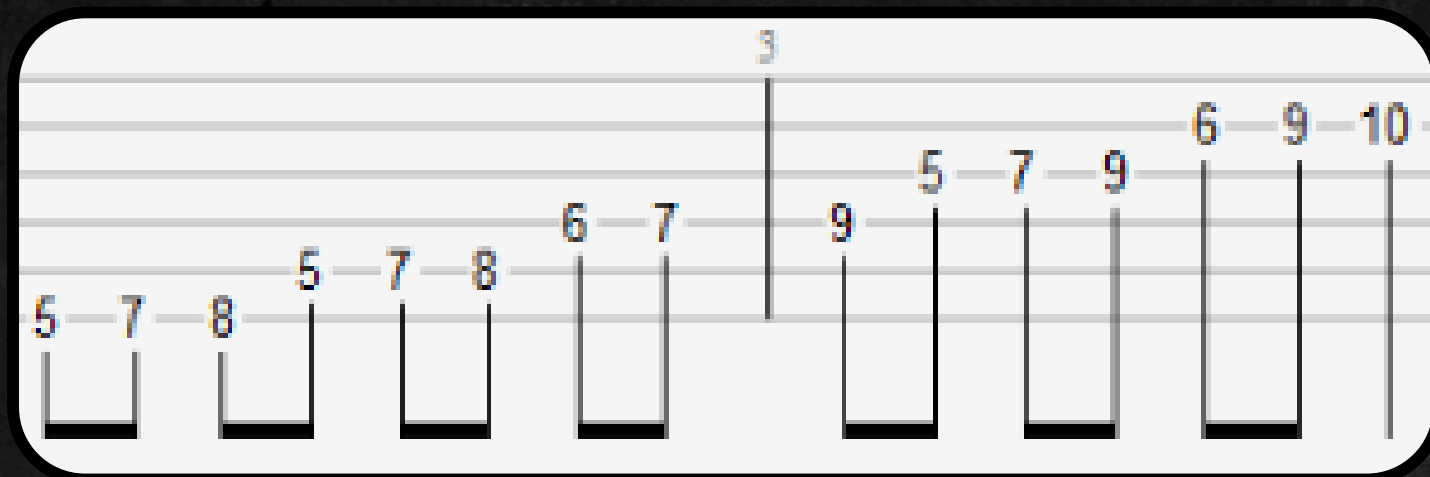
When to use: the hirajoshi scale can be treated and implemented just like the regular minor scale, but has more of a Japanese sound due to the order of its intervals.

Tip: this scale has a bit of phrygian flavor to it, so when you're playing over a phrygian movement (i - bII) you can play the hirajoshi scale starting from a tone below the root i.e. C hirajoshi works over D phrygian.

Example chord progression: Am | Bm7b5 | G

HARMONIC MINOR

Intervals: root, 2nd, min 3rd, 4th, 5th, min 6th, maj 7th



The A harmonic minor scale (2 octaves)

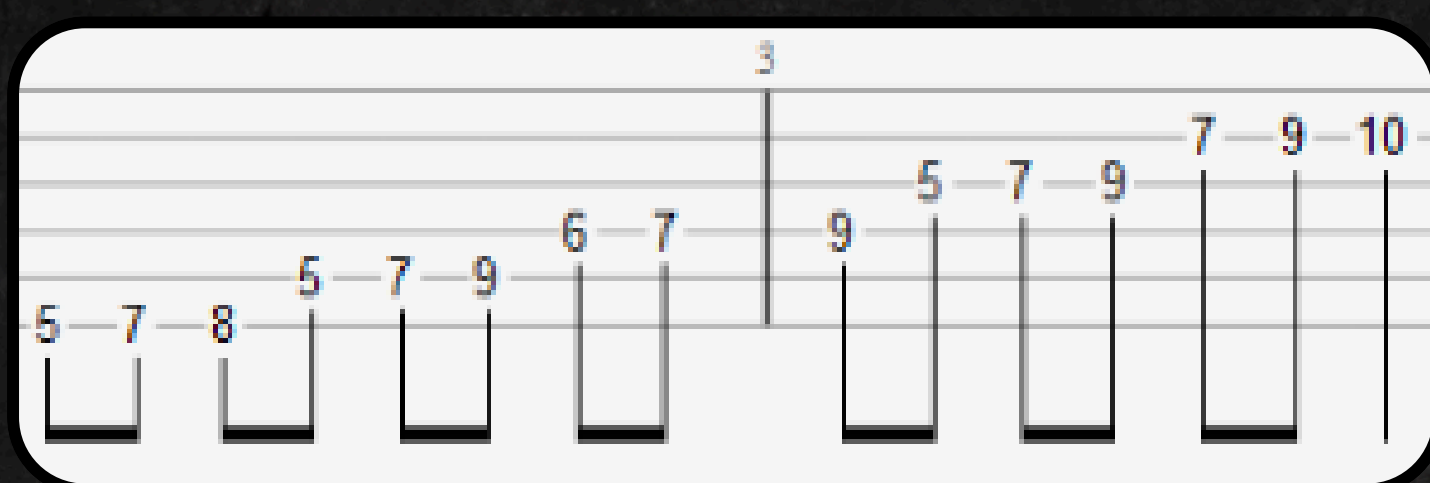
When to use: the harmonic minor scale can be used interchangeably with the regular minor scale to give it a bit of extra flavor. However, for maximum effectiveness it should be played over the V (dominant) of a minor key i.e. over E/E7 when in the key of Am.

Tip: the key to nailing the sound of the harmonic minor scale is to play around that sharp 7th interval. Doing trills/triplets between the sharp 7th and the root is a great example that's very effective.

Example chord progression: Am | E7

MELODIC MINOR

Intervals: root, 2nd, min 3rd, 4th, 5th, maj 6th, maj 7th



The A melodic minor scale (2 octaves)

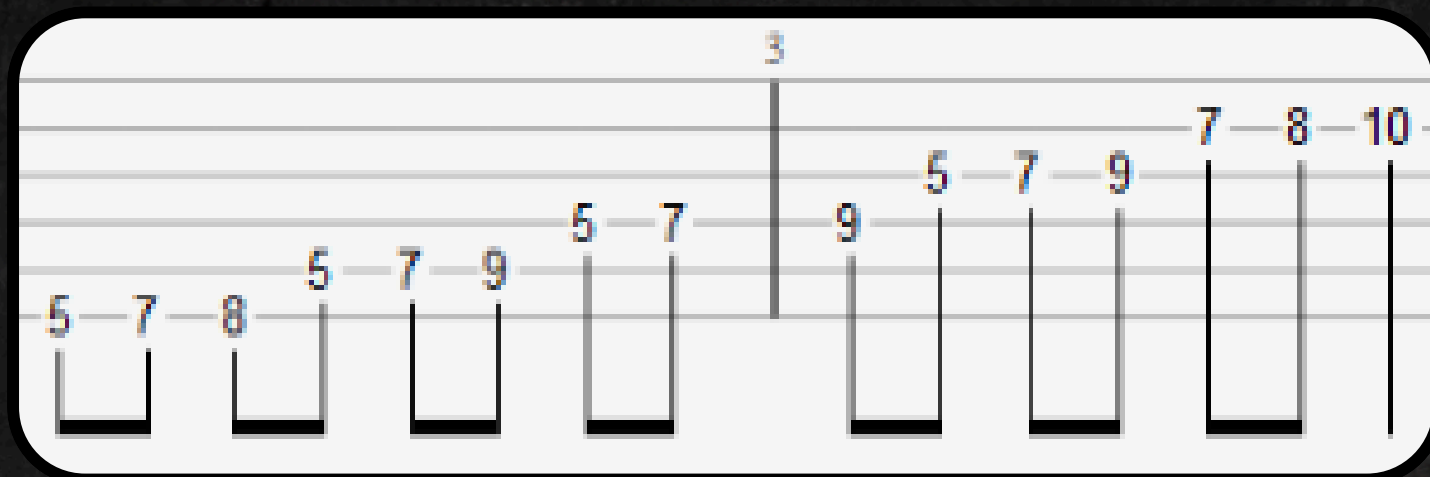
When to use: the melodic minor scale can be used interchangeably with the harmonic minor scale, with the maj 6th interval giving it a slightly different flavor to its counterpart.

Tip: melodic minor is effective when you really want to double-down on that Neoclassical sound the harmonic minor scale establishes. Resolving a phrase with the 6th, 7th and root in sequence will really reinforce that sound.

Example chord progression: Am | E7

DORIAN

Intervals: root, 2nd, min 3rd, 4th, 5th, maj 6th,
min 7th



The A dorian scale (2 octaves)

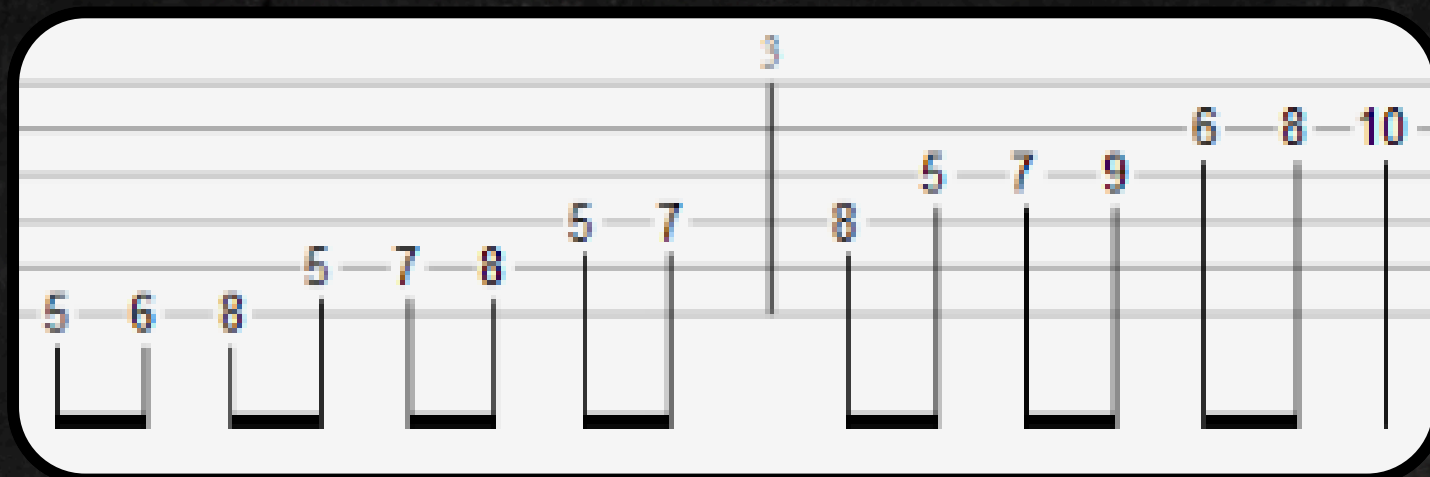
When to use: the dorian scale is most often used simply as a replacement for the minor pentatonic/minor Blues scale, using that special sharp 6th interval to add a bit of extra flavor.

Tip: dorian is most effective when used over the IV major chord of a minor key i.e. over D when in Am.

Example chord progression: Am | D

PHRYGIAN

Intervals: root, min 2nd, min 3rd, 4th, 5th, min 6th, min 7th



The A phrygian scale (2 octaves)

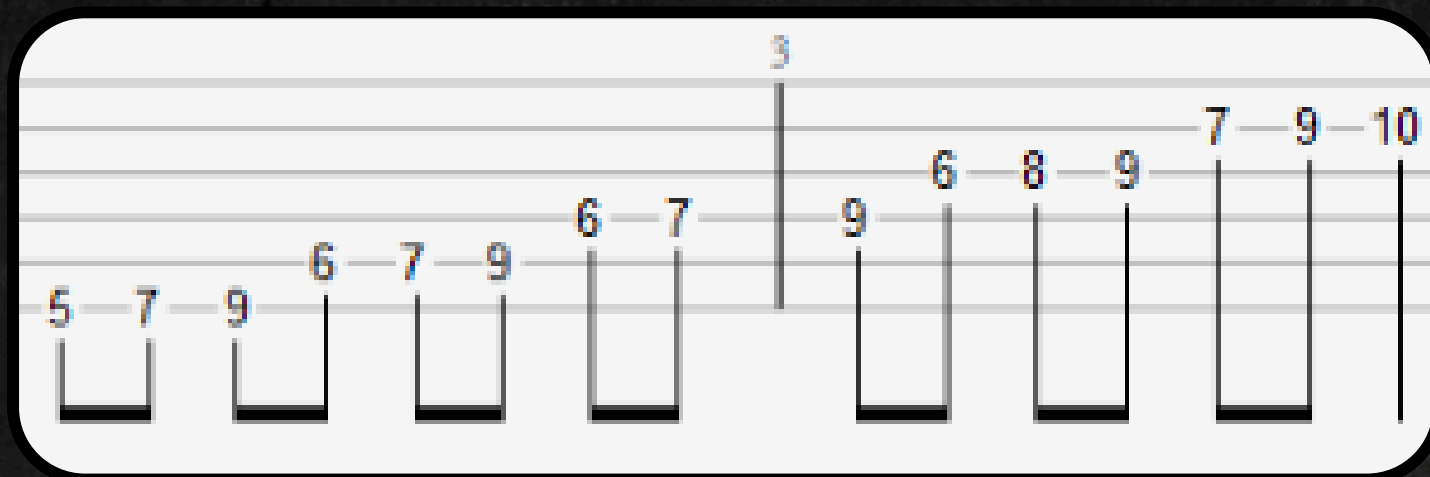
When to use: phrygian is most effective when used over the bII major chord of a minor key i.e. over Bb when in Am. Just listen out for that tell-tale half-step chord movement; you hear it everywhere in Metal!

Tip: the key to unlocking that signature phrygian sound is to abuse that minor 2nd interval. Really accentuate it by using it in conjunction with its neighbouring notes via trills, triplets and fast note clusters.

Example chord progression: Am | Bb

LYDIAN

Intervals: root, 2nd, maj 3rd, sharp 4th, 5th,
maj 6th, maj 7th



The A lydian scale (2 octaves)

When to use: lydian is most effective when used over the II major chord of a major key i.e. over B when in A.

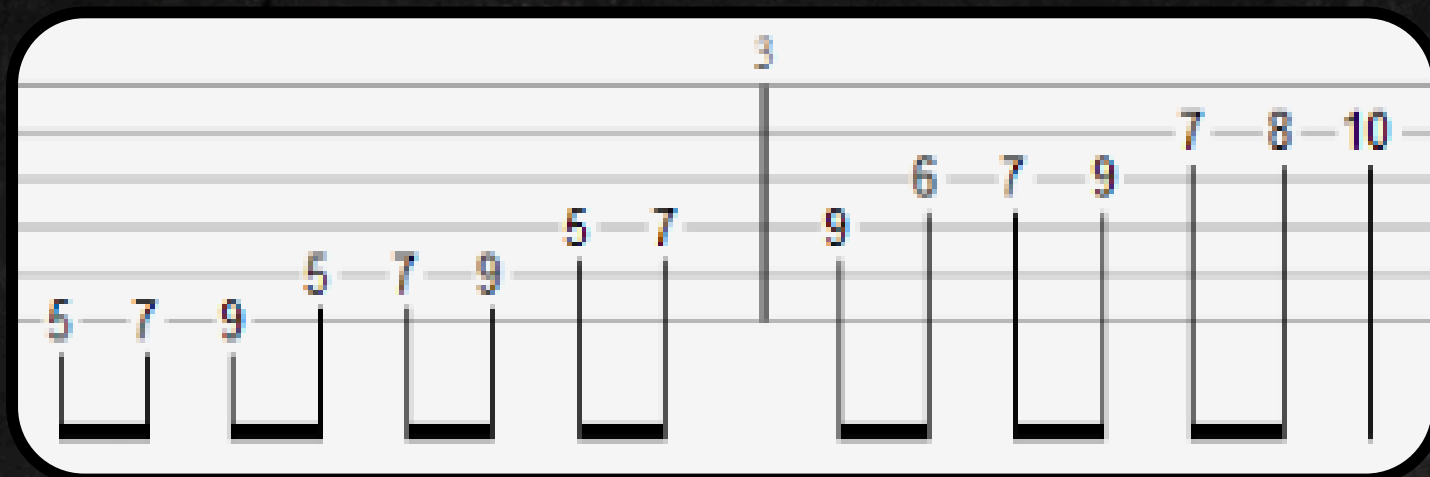
Tip: the key to unlocking that signature lydian sound is to abuse that sharp 4th interval.

Bending it up a half-step to the 5th is super effective, as is doing single string legato runs down the scale for that instant Satriani/Petrucci vibe.

Example chord progression: A | B

MIXOLYDIAN

Intervals: root, 2nd, maj 3rd, 4th, 5th, maj 6th, min 7th



The A mixolydian scale (2 octaves)

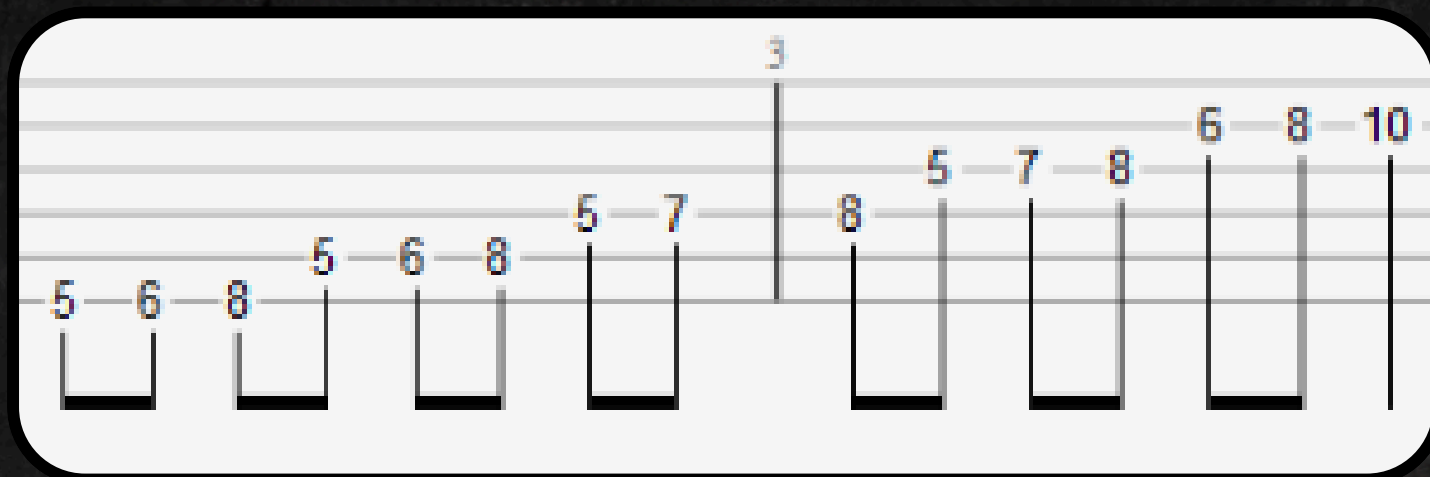
When to use: mixolydian is most effective when used over the bVII major chord of a major key i.e. over G when in A.

Tip: if you're having trouble implementing the mixolydian scale into your playing, perhaps try the mixolydian pentatonic instead (page 8). It's a slightly cut-down version of the scale but still retains its signature sound.

Example chord progression: A | G

LOCRIAN

Intervals: root, min 2nd, min 3rd, 4th, flat 5th, min 6th, min 7th



The A locrian scale (2 octaves)

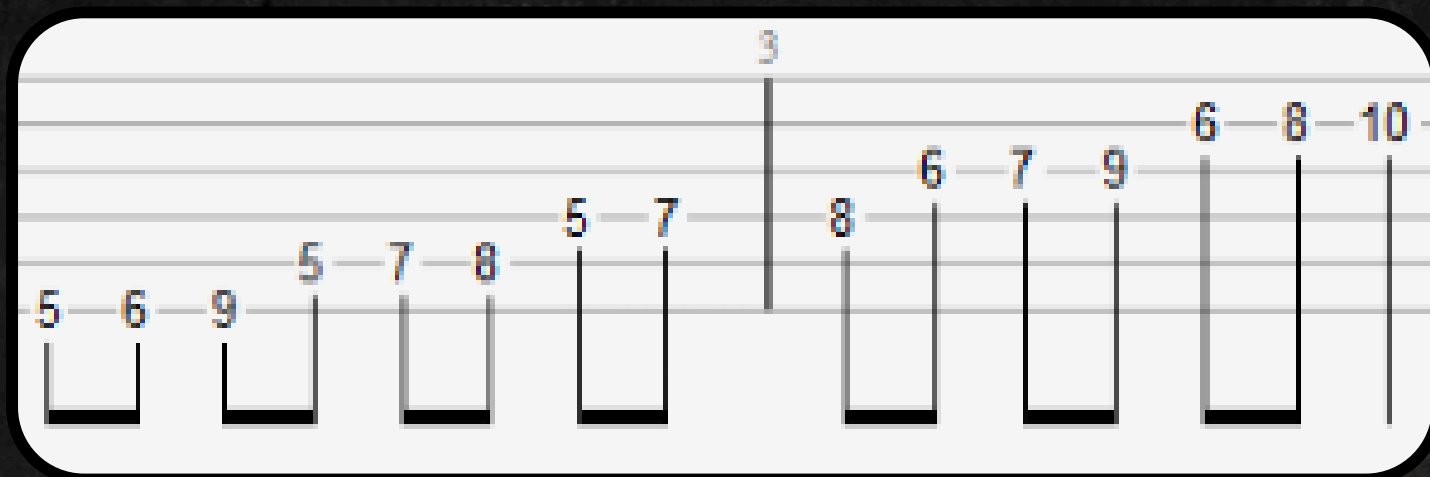
When to use: because locrian includes the minor 3rd and flat 5th intervals, the only use case for this unique scale is over diminished chords.

Tip: the whole crux of locrian is around the diminished tonality, so really accentuate that flat 5th interval. Also remember that the scale is built around a half-diminished chord, not a full diminished 7th chord, so if you want to get fancy with it you must remember this difference.

Example chord progression: Amin7b5

PHRYGIAN DOMINANT

Intervals: root, min 2nd, maj 3rd, 4th, 5th, min 6th, min 7th



The A phrygian dominant scale (2 octaves)

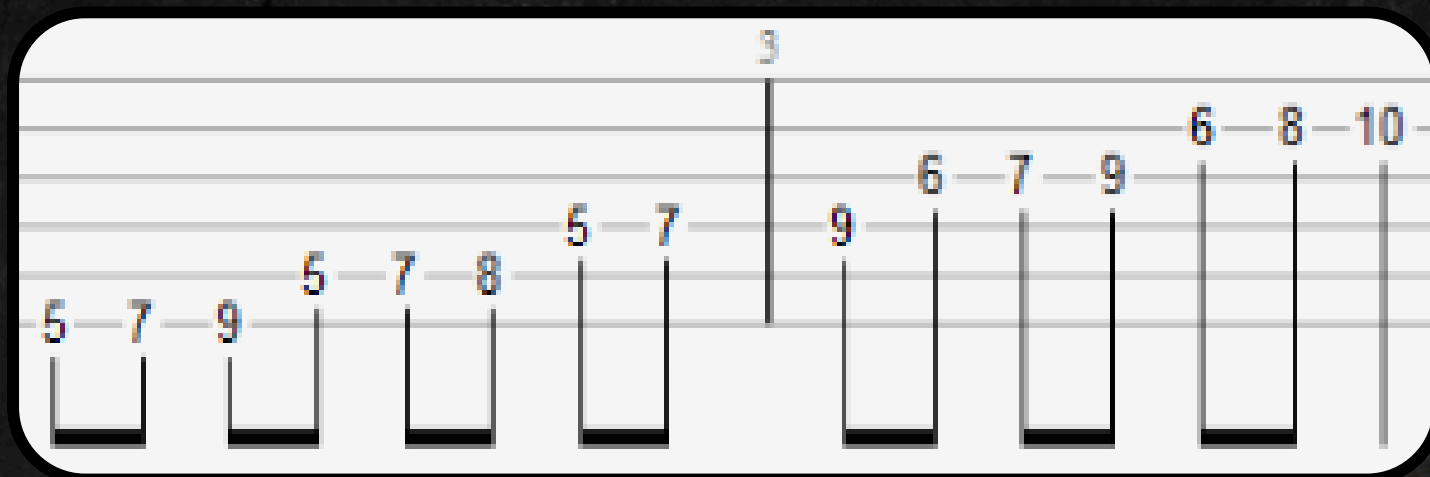
When to use: the phrygian dominant scale has a similar application to the regular phrygian scale, except that the root chord must be major, not minor. So whenever you see a chord movement like A > Bb (and not Am > Bb) you can use phrygian dominant.

Tip: phrygian dominant is the 5th mode of the harmonic minor scale, so if you're having trouble remembering the fingerings just go a 4th up from the root and play the harmonic minor scale i.e A phrygian dominant and D harmonic minor are the same thing).

Example chord progression: A | Bb

MIXOLYDIAN FLAT 6

Intervals: root, 2nd, maj 3rd, 4th, 5th, min 6th, min 7th



The A mixolydian b6 scale (2 octaves)

When to use: the mixolydian b6 scale is best used over the famous iv minor chord of a major key i.e. over Dm when in A.

Tip: to really capture the full drama of this epic scale you should, unsurprisingly, accentuate that magical flat 6th interval when playing over the iv minor chord, and then resolve it back to the natural 6th or major 3rd afterwards for maximum impact.

Example chord progression: A | Dm

